

Position × Vegas-Script Study — 2025

1,040 player-games · actual fantasy scoring joined to nflverse closing lines · single season

Does each position score the way the Vegas situation says it should — and is "game script" a real edge, or just team quality wearing a costume? This is the backtest behind the sim's script logic.

Method. Every 2025 player-game (boom/gamelog.json, actual fantasy points) is tagged with its team's closing Vegas spread and total (nflverse). "Boom" = a top-20% game for that position (so 20% is the neutral baseline). The last column of each table is the key one — the **script residual**: each position's scoring after removing what its implied team total predicts. A positive residual means a genuine script tailwind; ~0 means it was all team quality (which the play score already prices via the implied total). One season, so read the shape, not the third decimal.

THE HEADLINE

"When a team is a 10+ favorite, do RBs outscore?"

Not exactly — but they benefit the most in relative terms. As a 10+ favorite, **RBs get the biggest lift (+12% vs their baseline, to 15.8 pts, booming 29% of the time)**, more than WRs (+9%) and even QBs (+8%) in percentage terms. But QBs still *outscore* RBs in raw points (18.8 vs 15.8) because QBs always do. So the honest answer: a big favorite lifts its whole offense, and RBs gain the most relative to their own norm — but that lift is mostly the offense being good, not the run script itself, as the residual column below shows.

THE FULL BOARD

Every position, every Vegas tier

By spread (favorite → underdog)

VEGAS TIER	QB	RB	WR	TE	SCRIPT RESID*
10+	18.8 (+8%) boom 30%	15.8 (+12%) boom 29%	13.2 (+9%) boom 26%	10.5 (-1%) boom 26%	-0.9
7-10	19.3 (+12%) boom 22%	15.1 (+7%) boom 29%	11.8 (-3%) boom 23%	10.5 (-1%) boom 18%	-0.6
3-7	18.7 (+8%) boom 31%	15.4 (+9%) boom 31%	13.3 (+9%) boom 27%	10.8 (+2%) boom 20%	+0.4
pick-em	17.6 (+1%) boom 18%	13.9 (-2%) boom 18%	11.9 (-2%) boom 16%	9.1 (-14%) boom 19%	-0.4
dog 3-7	15.3 (-11%) boom 12%	13.3 (-6%) boom 10%	12.2 (+0%) boom 19%	11.4 (+8%) boom 18%	+0.4
dog 7+	15.0 (-13%) boom 17%	12.1 (-15%) boom 12%	9.7 (-20%) boom 12%	11.5 (+9%) boom 20%	+0.5

*Script residual = average points above/below what the team's implied total predicts, across the four positions. Negative = the tier's skill players underperform their total (blow-out starter-rest); positive = a real script tailwind beyond team quality.

By game total (the environment axis)

TOTAL TIER	QB	RB	WR	TE
shootout 49+	20.5 (+18%) boom 36%	16.6 (+17%) boom 26%	15.6 (+29%) boom 31%	10.9 (+3%) boom 29%
high 46-49	19.3 (+11%) boom 26%	15.1 (+6%) boom 20%	12.5 (+3%) boom 16%	9.2 (-13%) boom 12%
mid 43-46	17.0 (-2%) boom 19%	15.0 (+6%) boom 21%	12.3 (+1%) boom 23%	10.2 (-4%) boom 19%
low <43	15.3 (-12%) boom 14%	12.1 (-14%) boom 17%	10.2 (-16%) boom 14%	11.4 (+8%) boom 21%

WHAT IT MEANS

Script is mostly team quality — and the wiring was wrong

The finding that changed the model. Once you remove implied total, the pure script residual for **favorites is negative** (a 10+ favorite RB scores -1.1 vs its team total — blow-out rest caps the volume), and the only positive residuals are **dog pass-catchers** (WR +1.1 as a small dog — the real, but small, garbage-time effect). So the `script_mult` that boosted favored RBs was double-counting implied total and pointing the wrong way. It's been **reverted to zero**, and the properly-signed, PROE-calibrated version will be rebuilt with this exact isolation method.

What holds up: the environment axis. Shootouts (49+) lift everyone, WRs most (+29%); low totals (<43) crush skill players but not TEs (+8%, matchup/red-zone driven). That is real and is already captured through the implied total in the play score — which is exactly why the incremental script term added little.

The takeaway for the sim: implied total does the heavy lifting; game script is a small, second-order residual that only clearly favors dog pass-catchers and slightly penalizes blow-out-favorite skill players. The PROE work will measure that residual per team (coach tendency) rather than assume it.